

Chapter 156-2

Liang Shi drove while Xu Qingzhu sat quietly in the passenger seat. The car was too quiet, but Xu Qingzhu still forced herself to stay alert, asking Liang Shi about her life on set in a desultory manner.

Who she had met, what scenes she had filmed.

Liang Shi answered each question, but these were all unfamiliar territories for Xu Qingzhu. She listened with little interest, even drowsily, yet she still forced herself to stay awake and listen, being the most supportive audience for Liang Shi's uninteresting life.

Just listening to her voice made Liang Shi feel exhausted.

Finally, she couldn't hold back anymore and said softly: "Baby, if you're tired, just sleep."

Her voice trailed off with a hint of choking.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the car window and looked at Liang Shi seriously from the side: "I'm not tired."

Yet her eyes were clearly reddened, her upper and lower eyelids fighting to stay open.

"Be good." Liang Shi's voice grew even softer. "I'll wake you when we arrive."

"I'm really not tired." Xu Qingzhu propped up her head with one hand, fingers threading through her hair. "You rarely come back. I want to look at you more."

Xu Qingzhu said with a smile: "I haven't seen you for days. I missed you so much."

"You can look at me slowly after we get home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu still didn't listen to her. Her head just swayed against the car window. She didn't fall asleep, but her eyelids drooped down, leaving only a sliver open.

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The moment the car stopped, Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes.

Before Liang Shi could sit in her seat and space out, Xu Qingzhu got up and stretched exaggeratedly. But because the space inside the car was cramped, her arm bumped against the car window, causing her to gasp in pain.

"Looks like I've really been working overtime too hard lately." Xu Qingzhu muttered to herself. "Once I'm done with this busy period, I definitely need to rest."

There was a sense of forced casualness to it.

Liang Shi looked at her, her eyes glistening.

Because Xu Qingzhu was pretending so earnestly and working so hard at it, Liang Shi couldn't bear to expose her.

"Let's go home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu opened the car door. "Finally, I can go home."

She would never have said that before. Usually, she would just say: "Okay." Or "Let's go."

More and more words, a tone that kept rising higher.

All of it revealed her deliberateness.

Liang Shi categorized her deliberateness as: feigning ease.

If her acting skills were better, Liang Shi would have been drawn into the illusion she wove.

But her acting skills weren't good. Her clumsy performance made it easy to see through her exhaustion.

Even though she was already trying so hard.

But Liang Shi really knew her too well.

They clearly hadn't been together for that long, yet her every small movement, every expression, seemed to be engraved in Liang Shi's mind.

As long as she said one sentence, Liang Shi could almost imagine the next one in her head.

The two entered the elevator quietly. From the moment they got out of the car, Xu Qingzhu had been clinging to Liang Shi's arm, practically walking pressed against her.

All the way to the door, where Liang Shi unlocked it and went inside.

It wasn't until they were standing in the entryway that Xu Qingzhu suddenly remembered something and frantically turned off the living room light that had already been switched on.

"Wait a moment." Without even changing her shoes, Xu Qingzhu ran into the living room, grabbed a bundle of things from the sofa, and went back to the bedroom.

Actually, Liang Shi had seen it the moment they entered.

It was a blanket and pillow.

During the days she was away, Xu Qingzhu had been sleeping on the sofa.

Liang Shi stood in the entryway, at a loss.

Suddenly, she didn't know what to say.

Her heart was filled with sourness, like biting into an unripe apricot in early spring—a mouthful of bitterness.

Liang Shi stood in the entryway like a puppet, not turning on the lights again.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu, having hurriedly thrown the blanket and pillow back into the bedroom, suddenly realized something as she walked out. She stood there, eyes meeting Liang Shi's in the darkness.

Liang Shi had taken off her coat and could hang it accurately on the coat hook even in the dark.

Underneath was a lotus-pink sweater paired with black skinny pants, making her legs look slender and long.

Liang Shi didn't say anything, just bent down to change into slippers.

From not far away, she could precisely sense Xu Qingzhu's embarrassment and helplessness.

Xu Qingzhu stood there, her ten fingers interlaced.

"Um..." Xu Qingzhu spoke into the silence, then stopped.

As if she didn't know how to explain.

Liang Shi smiled slightly. "Sleeping on the sofa—aren't you afraid of catching a cold?"

By tacit understanding, neither of them turned on the room lights, moving forward in the dark.

Xu Qingzhu said: "It's okay, just... there's been a lot of work lately, so I kept working on the sofa, and when I got tired, I'd just fall asleep."

She finally thought of an excuse. "I did catch a slight cold after sleeping there one night, so I brought the blanket out. Actually, I only slept there for two days..."

Her voice grew weaker as she spoke, because Liang Shi had already walked up to her.

Moonlight passed through the glass, casting a room full of silver radiance.

Xu Qingzhu raised her head to meet Liang Shi's gaze. Those light brown pupils were beautiful, yet seemed somewhat cold and distant.

As if nothing could be taken to heart by her.

Even though her own reflection was mirrored in those pupils.

Xu Qingzhu licked her lips. She slowly raised her hand to touch Liang Shi's jawline, calling her name earnestly and intently: "Liang Shi."

"I'm here." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes briefly. Glistening tears hung on her eyelashes. "I don't want to lie to you."

Liang Shi responded softly: "I know."

"I missed you so much." Xu Qingzhu said.

"I know." Liang Shi said: "Me too..."

Before Liang Shi could finish her words, Xu Qingzhu tiptoed up and kissed her.

Her coat was thrown on the ground. Both arms wrapped tightly around Liang Shi's neck, her whole body hanging on Liang Shi.

It had the desolate feeling of a road movie reaching its end—the last rays of sunset shining on a cliff's edge.